

Heraclitus: everything is in flux



In contrast to the school of philosophy founded by Thales at Miletus, just along the Ionian coast in the city of Ephesus lived a solitary thinker, Heraclitus, with very different philosophical views. Rather than suggesting a single element from which everything was derived, he suggested an underlying principle – that of change. Heraclitus saw everything as consisting of opposing properties or tendencies, which come together to make up the substance of the world. The analogy he gave was that the path up a mountain is the same as the path down.

In this theory, known as the 'unity of opposites', the tension and contradiction of opposing forces is what creates reality, but it is inherently unstable. Therefore, everything is constantly changing: everything is in flux. Just as the water in a river is constantly flowing onwards, but the river itself remains the same, that which we consider to be permanent, unchanging reality consists not of objects, but processes.